

Buying Tips

1. While buying a home theatre system keep in mind what kind of speakers you want. If you want rear speakers, remember that you have to lay out wires all over the room. This can be avoided only with the wireless speakers.
2. Decide whether you want a DVD player or a Blu-ray system. The latter will cost you more but you will be investing for the future. The Blu-ray format supports much more data than normal DVDs.
3. Look for the connections. If you are looking to connect various input devices into the receiver, then check if there is enough space provided for each connection. For occasional connectors like the iPod, there is the front panel input so that you can easily connect and disconnect the device.
4. While buying a system, check and compare the warranty offered for the product.
5. Look for an audio/video receiver that supports your speakers and gives you sufficient connectors so that you can connect various input/output devices to them.

level a little bit. The receiver sends the video on to the TV and the audio is sent to the decoder. The decoder recognises and sorts out the different sound channels from the video signal and then sends the information to the amplifiers for each sound-channel output. These amplifiers are connected to the appropriate speakers.

Surround sound formats. The work of the audio/video receiver is to receive the surround sound information encoded in the video signals and drive the appropriate speakers. The audio/video speakers of a home theatre system are equipped to decode different formats—Dolby Laboratories and digital theatre systems. The former include various formats like Dolby Digital and Dolby Pro Logic and the latter has also created a lot of DTS digital theatre formats.

Here are a few things that you need to know about the two companies: DTS encoding uses less compression than Dolby encoding. This means DTS sound is clearer and sharper. But DTS is less commonly used in DVD and other television broadcasts. Most DVD players offer the Digital Dolby option and only a few offer DTS sound. While buying a home theatre system, you should be clear which format you want, though, now most of the systems come with a combination of both.

Another important aspect that you

need to keep in mind is how many speakers you want for the surround sound set-up. The most common options available are 5.1, 6.1 and 7.1 surround. Here, 5.1 means that 5 channels will be available and .1 indicates an additional channel for a subwoofer. So is the case with 6.1 and 7.1—6 and 7 channels, respectively, with one subwoofer for each. The work of the subwoofer is to carry low-frequency sound and to give a bass boost and create the rumbling effect for certain special sound effects, such as a car explosion, plane crash, collisions, etc. 5.1 supports Dolby Digital, Dolby Pro Logic II and DTS 5.1. DTS 96/24 uses a 5.1 channel format to play audio at the same sampling rate at which it was recorded.

A 6.1 speaker has an additional rear speaker. The formats it supports are Dolby Digital EX, DTS-ES and DTS Neo 6. In the case of 7.1, there are two additional speakers compared to 5.1, which are placed on the left and right at the rear. The formats that it supports are Dolby Pro Logic IIx

DVD player. The input device for a home theatre system can be a DVD player or a satellite dish antenna. There are various kinds of DVD players—standard, portable, DVD players with recording facility and Blu-ray DVD players.

The prices of these players depend on the features that they support. Standard DVD players are typically

40×5×25 cm in size. They operate on household mains power and are meant to be connected to a TV. These players can play DVDs, audio CDs, MP3 and video CDs. A few of these players support Dolby Digital and DTS formats. Some of them also support the MPEG-4 format, which is commonly available on the Internet. Their price ranges from Rs 7000 to Rs 5000.

Portable DVD players have a small LCD screen attached to them and they run on Li-ion batteries. These devices priced at from Rs 8000 to Rs 15,000. DVD players with recording feature are a little more expensive than standard players as they have a hard disk for recordings that can be erased later. The cost of these players ranges from Rs 7000 to Rs 15,000.

The Blu-ray DVD players are of a totally different kind as they are compatible with high-definition (HD) TV. This technology allows five times the capacity of a normal DVD. They are basically developed to record, rewrite and playback HD videos. They support MPEG2, MPEG4, VC1 and provide superior surround sound with 7.1 channel theatre-quality sound.

Connectors. Connectors are a critical part of a home theatre system as they are the hub of your home-entertainment system. So have a look at all the connectors that are available so that you get the maximum for your system. You may look for interface support for DVD players, HDMI port, VCR, cable or satellite box, etc. If you have HDMI support then it lets you feed high-definition signals from a cable box or Blu-ray through the receiver to your TV. These ports also provide you the best quality picture from a standard DVD player.

The first and last point that you need to keep in mind is to choose a system that suits your requirements and budget. Also, keep in mind the future compatibility of components with new devices that are being released in the market. ●

The author is a technical correspondent at Efy